A RACE FOR ALL TIME:

An American Myth, the Roaring 20s, and a 480-Mile Footrace up California's Coast

Chapter 1

Day One: Go!

The Opening Mile

When the gun went off, the runners bolted off the steps of the Civic Center and hammered up Market Street. They whizzed past the storefronts and the spectators, who bobbed and yelled as they watched the men rush by beneath the dissipating fog. The runners kept up a consistent, punishing clip. For everyone craning to see them pass, there was time only for a glance of the crisp white singlets, of the few sandal-clad feet among the leather boxing shoes, of the many pistoning limbs, and then they were gone.

The best sprinters in the world reach peak velocity and start to fatigue within 100 meters, on a rubber track, in ideal race conditions. The near-sprint that the group delivered as they opened their trek was merely a treat for the spectators, and probably also a quick way to expel some of the pre-race jitters that had been building all morning during the cramped and chaotic warm up. Mile One, all told, would be the fastest of 480.

The group hurried north. The longest strides belonged to "Sweek Eagle," (one W.E. Simpson) who stood at 5′11″ and weighed just over 160 pounds, making him the group's Goliath. Some of his competitors barely reached his chin. In fact, a shorter, "sturdy" physique (as the running commentary of the time called it) characterized Native runners in the American public imagination. Spectators and journalists routinely commented on Native runners' short and "choppy" strides that were unlike the textbook techniques promoted by white coaches across the Western athletic world: long, reaching steps on the balls of the feet. Sweek Eagle, at least, must have looked like a hurdler by comparison, chewing up the ground below him, but the others were barreling along by his side, their bib numbers pinned to their chests:

1: Rushing Water

2: Flying Cloud

3: Fighting Stag

4: Falcon

5: Mad Bull

6: Thunder Cloud

7: Sweek Eagle

8: Big White Deer

9: Jamon

10: Melika

11: Chochee

They bounded on towards the Bay, rushing into the colossal opportunity before them—a new scale of sport; a shot at athletic stardom. Brothers Melika and Chochee had run together in city marathons before this, and, as seasoned endurance athletes from a people that revered running, they were the most likely in the group to feel somewhat accustomed to the pomp and circumstance of organized urban races. Still, San Francisco was the second-largest city in the Western United States, and to have a lineup of all Native men run for the entertainment of a white crowd with cameras and cash prizes was a rare occurrence indeed. In fact, in this form, it had never happened. There must have been something special in the air, on Flag Day, 1927, when this field of runners began the first organized ultramarathon in United States history. If there wasn't *some* sense of that grandeur, the Zunis surely would have raised eyebrows at their zealous Karuk competitors and slowed to a more sensible pace. But the group progressed stride for stride.

That opening mile was iconic. It was intense—inspiring. It was everything the boosters needed to assure themselves that their event had some star power and potential. In truth, it must have been hard for *anyone* to fully comprehend that there were nearly 500 remaining.

A mile is 5,280 feet long. The mile, the *single* mile, has held and continues to hold so much importance in competitive running history. The midcentury race to break the 4-minute mark is still one of the most prized accomplishments in the annals of Western sport. While official recognition for the feat belongs to Englishman Roger Bannister, who broke the barrier in 1954, legend has it that in the 1870s, a Pawnee Scout for the U.S. Army known by the names Kutawikucu Resaru and "Big Hawk Chief" ran a 3:58, clocked and confirmed by an Army Officer (and second timer), in Sidney, Nebraska. Native runners starred in the stories and legends of American running triumphs, long before the 1920s.

The standard distance of 26 miles, 385 yards, became official for regulation marathon events after the 1908 London Olympics course measured that length. That very race was an athletic event that rewrote modern sport, producing one of the most dramatic finishes in Olympic history and popularizing the first-ever celebrity to be known primarily by a first name alone. It also launched a "marathon craze" that swept the nation and consumed it for years to

come, with the top contenders meeting again and again for long races in cramped, indoor venues, like the original Madison Square Garden in New York City. The facility could house a track measuring only a tenth of a mile, requiring the athletes to run over 250 laps to contest the marathon distance. The torture, it could be said, was part of the event. Indeed, in the early decades of the twentieth century, the marathon became *the* marquee event to prove one's manhood, even solidify the perceived supremacy of an imperial nation that produced international champions. Never an Olympic champion himself but widely regarded as the best distance runner in the world from about 1907 to 1912 was Tom Longboat, an Onondaga member of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy. In that time, he smashed the Boston Marathon record, beat all of his competitors from the 1908 Olympics (during which Longboat had a shocking collapse) as a professional athlere, and set a world record at the 15-mile distance, among other achievements. Native runners claimed many top spots in the earliest era of international races, even by the 1920s.

Four hundred eighty miles is 2,534,400 feet. It's 18.3 standard marathons. There was, of course, no established racing strategy or record at the 480-mile distance or anything remotely comparable in national or international running records. The new Redwood Highway, which ran through the coastal counties of the so-called "Redwood Empire" north of San Francisco Bay, simply stretched that far from its southern tip in Sausalito to the center of downtown Grants Pass, Oregon, just over the state border. People had completed staggeringly long feats of pedestrianism the world around, it's true, but not in the name of modern sport, not so meticulously refereed and recorded, and certainly not with such keen planning or capitalistic purpose. Whatever time won the race would become the course record, and a new standard by which one could measure manhood, as well as mental and physical fortitude.

The rule book, published in papers in the weeks leading up to the event, allowed the runners fifteen days and not a second more to complete the journey. The papers expected the endeavor to take only about ten. Everything they expected to need on the road was stashed in the caravan cars that followed the runners or would be provided in the host towns along the route or at special check-in stations complete with medical staff. Trainers, athletes, and organizers had obviously decided that it was all possible, but the following week would test their calculations. On some level, everyone involved was taking a leap of faith that this feat, in these conditions, on this road, could really be done. If any mortal men were capable, though, history suggested that they might very well be found in an all-Native lineup.

Yes, the opening mile was iconic, intense, and inspiring. It was also inconsequential, not only because of the scale of what was still to come, but because the race down Market Street brought all the runners to a halt at the docks. Winded from their burst (which dwindled over the final blocks in the city), the group had reached the northeast corner of the city's peninsula. In 1927, no Golden Gate Bridge spanned the strait that connects San Francisco Bay to the Pacific. Though major items on state agendas, bridges and paved roads were not yet ubiquitous even in heavily traveled areas in California. The city wouldn't start constructing its emblematic, red-orange "Bridge That Couldn't Be Built" for another six years. The Redwood Highway itself was only just completed—or, completed enough, anyway, to accommodate the caravan that the race would bring.

So, the only way to cross the water was via vessel, launched from the famous ferry terminal (an infrastructure project completed just before the turn of the twentieth century). The men shuffled onto a ferry and caught their breath as the boat started to carry them across the choppy water. The excitement of the city and the dash out of it warranted whatever exhaustion they felt, but it was nothing compared to what was to come: one mile down, *nearly 500* to go. No matter how many times one hears it, the scale is, truly, hard to comprehend. Even a dozen miles or a single marathon sounds entirely negligible compared to the total. Surely even by the end of the day, a few runners would fall five, ten, twenty-five miles behind the leader. What would be the point of no return, when there was no catching up, or, even worse, simply no more gas in the tank?

In the Bay

The pause in action on the ferry was a forced moment for reflection, as well as some sightseeing. Ferrying from the terminal building to Marin County, California, requires a route that passes by Alcatraz Island, another famous San Francisco landmark. "The Rock," the island's main prison structure, is a concrete cellblock atop a cliffy hill, close enough to the city for its inhabitants to see and hear the thrills of urban life and yet a muted world unto itself. The island held several hundred military prisoners in 1927, not yet a full-fledged federal penitentiary. Some of the inmates surely gazed back at the passerby as the ferry drew close and then sputtered away.

The ferrygoers probably did not know about the nineteen Hopi prisoners that the government forced to labor in the detention barracks on the island in 1895, before the construction of the main block. Government officials passed down the sentence as a result of Hopi resistance to land encroachment and forced assimilation. It was the largest, though not the

only group of Native prisoners sent to Alcatraz in its early days, and it was composed of runners, famed in and beyond the mesas of the Southwest, much like the Zuni. The ferry passengers also, of course, could never have known the significance the island would go on to have in the civil rights struggle of all Native people come 1969 when, complete with its defunct, abandoned, and dilapidated infrastructure, it would become the central site of the American Indian Movement.

The legacies of Native runners, the promise of Native futures—these imprints were all around, though rendered nearly invisible by the forces that so boldly built the modern United States in the Roaring Twenties. It's impossible to know whether or not any of the eleven contestants in the Redwood Highway Marathon thought about their undertaking in a broader context of history, identity, or even activism. It's impossible to know whether they had a sense of the power they held in simply accepting the invitation to race, despite the stereotypes in the advertising. It's impossible to know what was really on their minds at all as San Francisco shrunk into the distance, the Zunis creeping ever-further away from home, and the Karuks beginning their long treks back towards familiar territory.

This moment on the ferry was the one and only time that the racers would be permitted to advance by any means other than foot. If and when a runner left the road for any reason (most probably to sleep or eat, whether in a nice hotel wanting to put them up for publicity or tucked away in the roadside brush to save time), he was to return to the exact spot he left and resume his road coverage from that point. There were few other rules to worry about. They had all been determined eligible by meeting the one-fourths "Indian blood quantum" standard set by the organizers. They knew they couldn't accept lifts, but would be trailed by their team of personnel and supplies. They had already been awarded sponsors, usually the Chambers of Commerce and boosters organizations in the towns along the highway. The Grants Pass Cavemen, for instance, sponsored the three Southard Brothers and Henry "Flying Cloud" Thomas.

Those four were, most likely, also glad to be rid of the daily training their "coach" had devised over the past few months. A local mogul in their home town of Happy Camp, one Herbert G. Boorse, manager of the General Store, had ridden next to his charges, bellowing at them from his car as he trailed them on almost-daily sixty-mile runs in the Siskiyou Mountains. He also made them take cold dunks in the river. To be fair, the athletes had also done some training on pavement to acclimate their bodies to the surface and they all appeared to be in fabulous shape and free from injury as the race got underway. It was apparently also Boorse who had suggested the fake "Indian names" to convey an ethnic image that would feel more authentic to non-Native onlookers.

The Zunis had traveled north with their own coach, a regionally well-known white trader in Native goods who had, for years, promoted tourist events focused on Native culture in New Mexico. Kirk was also the regional commissioner for the Amateur Athletic Union, or AAU, the governing body of amateur sports and certifier of official sporting records. Sports administrators formed the organization in New York in 1888 to coordinate elite athletic competition and coordinate the participation of athletes in the Olympics (open *only* to amateur athletes, not professionals, until the 1980s). Kirk coached other high-profile Native athletes, perhaps most notably Hopi Nicolas Qömawunu, who had just weeks ago achieved a decisive win in the New York to Long Beach Marathon on May 15. Kirk was still bragging about Qömawunu's performance and daring others to challenge him on the eve of the Redwood Highway Marathon. He made for a good character in the press, too. In a promotional article for the Redwood Highway Marathon, the *Healdsburg Tribune* reported, "Mike says that the Redwood highway Indian marathon is in a class by itself, and in giving instruction to his henchmen to select the Zunis to come to San Francisco he said, 'Pick three of the toughest and best.'" Henchmen aside, one must appreciate Kirk's commitment to promoting Native running; barely two weeks separated his train ride home from New York with Qömawunu and other Hopi athletes and his departure with the three Zunis to California. He was, to be sure, at least in part driven by a desire to do well for himself, recognizing the possibilities for profit in promoting the widespread voyeurism of Native life. Along the way, Kirk established lasting connections with Native people, organizing displays of and widely publicizing Native talent not just in running, but also in art and dance.

The time for resting and reflecting came to a close. As if to punctuate that point, race organizers staged a second official "start" when the race resumed in Sausalito. Less grand in scope and publicity potential, it was nonetheless a grand event for the first of many North-of-Bay towns the race would pass through. These towns, truly, were the prizes of the Redwood Empire that the boosters sought to advertise. Onlookers crowded the ferry wharf to greet the runners as they docked. The whole caravan of race personnel had come over from San Francisco, including Al Jennings and even a troupe of Oregon Cavemen. Runners lined up a second time, right on the back of the ferry, crouched and reasonably steady on the slightly-swaying vessel. They restarted the race right over the apron connecting the ferry to the loading dock when "erstwhile bandit" Jennings fired the second gunshot of the morning at precisely 11:32am. It was from this start that the official race clock started and from which miles covered tended to be reported. First off stairs, then off a boat. Eleven athletes on an impossible

mission, a bandit-politician holding the gun, race promoters in pressed suits and animal skins. It was a peculiar race indeed.

The Ruined Mission on San Rafael

As the runners fanned out, the fields of Marin County served as their backdrop. The sun was, as the afternoon approached, high overhead, if still obscured by some cloud coverage. The June sun above the Bay isn't known for burning heat. Mark Twain never actually made the famous quip that's been associated with him— "The coldest winter I ever spent was a summer in San Francisco,"—but the sentiment has rung true for many citygoers that have long experienced its "June Gloom." Still, any temperature that climbs into the 60s Fahrenheit is generally considered too warm for marathons. The runners would abandon long daytime intervals as the race went on, but on the first day, they all looked to make some progress and show off for the crowds.

It's about a ten-mile stretch from where the ferry docked in Sausalito to the city of San Rafael. With about 27,000 residents in 1927, San Rafael was on the front lines of Bay Area suburban growth. Railroad lines crossed over paved roads adorned by beautiful nineteenth-century Victorian mansions with manicured lawns. The most famous among them, a Gilded Age Queen Anne Victorian at 1408 Mission Ave, added a garage that year to fully partake in automobile culture. There were never homes, too, with parked cars out front. The town had just opened the central branch of a free county library system in the basement of the county courthouse and was continuing to turn Fourth Street into a downtown worthy of "city" status.[1] By 1927, the Orpheus Theater showed silent films and the Woolworth's sold mass produced housewares. It was a place full of modern amenities without the hurry-scurry of a city like San Francisco.

As the runners approached, sirens sounded to alert the residents to the excitement. The field of runners was moving much slower and sticking together in a pack now that they were settling in, but some last-minute jostling among them sent the youngest Zuni entrant, thirty-two-year-old Ernest Jamon (strictly referred to as "Jamon" in the papers) to the leading position at the official checkpoint downtown. It was an investment to cross into one of these established clerking locations in the front of the pack. Town representatives in San Rafael promised a purse of $100 to the runner that led the pack into town, provided that he also finish the race in Grants Pass. There were several such offers over the racecourse. Runners therefore

[1] https://cdm17213.contentdm.oclc.org/digital/collection/mcflhistory/search

had to balance the allure of additional cash prizes for speed with the need to endure hundreds of miles of hills and a week's worth of summer conditions ahead. It was a real concern. Surely, though, it was exciting for the viewers in San Rafael to watch Jamon throw his name in the ring with this early milestone victory. In fact, "Marvelous Marin" County had chosen him as their race representative—their adopted hometown hero. Kirk directed the Zunis to stop for a little rest and a rubdown, giving the crowd more time to shout words of encouragement to their representative.

Beneath the surface of the town's distinctly modern buzz and the palpable thrill of the Redwood Highway Marathon, however, lurked a darker face to the city, not unlike the way Alcatraz Island hid in plain sight in San Francisco. Like so many other nearby towns (and San Francisco itself), San Rafael had been home to a Spanish Mission, a Catholic outpost established to convert Native people, in an earlier era of settlement. Beginning in the 1760s and lasting until the 1830s, Spanish colonizers established and operated these settlements in lands that became California, Arizona, New Mexico, Texas, Georgia, and Florida. The sites typically housed and aimed to assimilate their residents, forcing them to labor on farms and ranches, or in construction or other manual trades. Often, a Spanish military fort stood nearby.

What many Americans associate with the Spanish missions today is their iconic architecture: arched entryways, clay tiles, and adobe walls in an appealing desert palette of creams and reds. But they are pretty buildings that once housed substantial horror. MISSION COLONIALISM.

The placename *San Rafael* refers to Saint Rafael the Archangel. Spanish Catholics erected the mission in his honor in 1817 to serve as a sanatorium for ill and injured prospective converts, likely suffering from European diseases such as measles and smallpox. Rafael was, afterall, the angel of healing in the Catholic faith. The mission closed and fell into disrepair only a few decades after it opened. The mission lived on in the city's name, but San Rafael tore down the ruins of the original structure in the 1870s. To inhabit early-twentieth-century California as a non-Native person was to live among these markers of turbulent and troubled histories, but seldom to recognize and certainly not to openly acknowledge them as shameful. To live in such spaces as an Indigenous person was to continually reckon with the legacy of colonial destruction.

There was only ever one mission site north of Mission San Rafael Arcángel, in Sonoma, which is about twenty-five miles away. The Spanish did not venture up into Karuk homelands, though American settlers would probe the remote regions of Northern California by the

mid-1800s. The Zunis, however, did experience Spanish colonialism as early as the sixteenth century. Some of the earliest and most famous Spanish explorers, like Francisco Vázquez de Coronado, searched in Zuni territory for lost cities and gold. Sustained colonial abuse followed in their wake with the creation of the Spanish *encomienda* system that forced Native people to labor and pay tribute to *encomenderos*, well-connected Spanish colonists who more or less operated as lords, though the role did not technically include land titles.

In addition to countless local acts of resistance, Native people throughout the Southwest delivered a massive blow to the Spanish in 1680 by launching a coordinated, large-scale resistance effort that has come to be known as the Pueblo Revolt, spearheaded by the Tewa religious leader known as Po'pay. The story cannot be told without emphasizing the pivotal role of messenger-runners who covered hundreds of miles on foot in order to deliver knotted ropes to the distinct pueblos throughout the region. The cords were physical count-downs: each day, the recipients should untie a single knot. When the last knot was untied, it was time to attack local Spanish missions. The resistance was successful; they ousted the Spanish for twelve years, and when they returned, it was without many of the features of their earlier iron fist. Spanish settlement continued in what came to be known as Alta California, which stretched from the Pacific Coast to the Rockies and went about as far north as San Francisco Bay before a firm boundary was established at the forty-second parallel. The successful Mexican War of Independence in 1821 resulted in Alta California becoming Mexican. The whole Southwest then came under the political control of the United States following the Mexican-American War in 1848 and with the last purchase of contiguous land in the 1850s.

The Redwood Highway did not directly pass the site of Mission San Rafael Arcángel. The city residents celebrated the Native runners who passed through, and the moment belonged to Ernest Jamon. But the day was still young. Any competitive long distance runner knows the peril of running in front. It's really hard to stay there. After his rubdown and chat with his coach, as he left the town that so graciously received him, Ernest Jamon might have already been feeling the blisters bubbling on his feet. The possibility of pain, of race-ending injury loomed just around the bend, just out of sight, just like the site of the once-Mission San Rafael Arcángel.

Splitting Up in the Night

The threat of injury caught up with the field in Petaluma, another twenty miles north, officially over a full standard marathon's distance from the start. However, it was not Jamon that fell first. Elder Barney, "Thunder Cloud" in the race, succumbed to a gruesome foot injury

described in the press as an infection born of the foot being "lanced" four times the prior day in an accident. He was only nineteen years old and eager to compete, but the race physician urged him to drop out. Barney was crushed by disappointment and retreated to his caravan to catch a ride and start recovering. He was the first casualty of the marathon, but he wouldn't be the last.

Some others in the field were running well. Henry "Flying Cloud" Thomas took over the lead as the afternoon wore on. The Southard brothers were still in good health too, as were most of the other Karuks. Melika and Chochee showed no signs of blisters or extreme fatigue.

Not willing to take chances with the injuries that high-impact running risks, James McNeil, the Karuk entrant competing under the name "Big White Deer," committed to walking the rest of the course. He bore his strength not in the sinewy leanness of most other endurance athletes but rather in some healthy heft. Was he going to be living proof of the wisdom of the tortoise over the hare? To be sure, walking 480 miles takes a remarkably heavy toll on the body, but it sends a gentler shockwave into the knees, stresses the hamstrings and quads less on each and every step. It was a gamble to run into town first; it was a gamble to walk into town last. Time would tell which race tactics were worth their wager.

McNeil made it to Petaluma in the evening and decided to call it a night. By that time, several of his competitors were already several towns further along the route and beginning to race into the night. And so one retired from the race and one went off to rest in the town that marketed itself as the "Egg Capital of the World." It was the site where a Canadian inventor named Lyman Byce invented the coal lamp egg incubator in 1879, shortly after he moved there. Such a feat might sound obscure, but egg incubating is as old as ancient civilizations and there were many inventive minds churning out designs for safe incubation machines that were less likely to burst into flames than the models used in the final decades of the nineteenth century. The town constructed a giant egg basket—one in which a crowd of at least a dozen people could stand—to show off in the National Egg Day parade it hosted.

These niche economies and local identifiers existed all along the Redwood Highway. In fact, small towns off of American highways are still places where one can see towering fiberglass giants in the likeness of lumberjacks or visit such attractions as the World's Largest Rocking Chair (Illinois), the World's Largest Ball of Twine (Kansas), and the mind-bending World's Largest Collection of the World's Smallest Versions of the World's Largest Things (also Kansas). These things might seem silly, but they were and always will be gambits to draw visitors with wallets. The boosters of the Redwood Empire Association and the towns along the Redwood Highway were all using the race as an opportunity to showcase these charming little

corners of the counties north of San Francisco, many of which had forged a civic identity centered on a particular crop or industry. Plus, being a Petaluma Egg Day Queen or an honored guest at Sebastopol's annual Apple Show was an honor. Seeing the barge floats at the Healdsburg Water Carnival or the floral displays at the Santa Rosa Rose Carnival could create lifelong memories. The papers were equally likely to report on what the host towns were known for as they were to talk solely about the standings in the marathon. To zero in on the athletic contest is to miss the impetus for the whole event.

The next significant sight of the day was the city of Santa Rosa (mere weeks out from civic workers sweeping away the last of the petals from the Rose Carnival). Henry Thomas made it there at 9:20pm and rested until about 11:00pm, when he headed out again just after Gorham, the youngest of the racing Southard brothers, came through in second place. Southard, running under the name "Rushing Water," trudged only just beyond town limits before finding a place to sleep for the night. David Huey, aka "Falcon," came into Santa Rosa at 11:18pm and also rested for a few hours, but would be one of several runners who would head out in the early morning and run overnight in the cooler air. Johnny "Mad Bull" Southard reached Santa Rosa just after midnight and ran right on through. "Sweek Eagle" Simpson trailed him by only a few minutes and did the same. The Zunis all arrived at Santa Rosa just before 2:00am and turned in for some sleep. Santa Rosa is over 45 miles from where the ferry had docked in Sausalito that morning.

Even as the night quieted and ended for many tired competitors, there was still wild excitement on the roads. The stretch leading into Healdsburg (another 15 miles up the highway) was lined by people waiting for "star attractions" on the land and in the skies. As if to underscore the need for constant spectacle and entertainment pulsing through American society in the 1920s, the night of June 14, 1927 also bore a total lunar eclipse visible in California and much of the rest of the country. The *Healdsburg Enterprise* reported that "the highway was thick with machines" and that "the eclipse of the moon came in for its full share of attention" after midnight. Henry Thomas reached the town around 3:00am, having logged almost sixty-five miles of running in seventeen hours with minimal rest.

It's easy to think that there was never a dull moment during the Redwood Highway Marathon. And yet, the road was long, to say the very least. Surely, some hours passed slowly and runners felt the strain of the monotony of their movement in their joints, their muscles, and their minds. Between towns, the bustle gave way to miles of quiet countryside. After the eclipse that first night, the moon shone bright, illuminating the open roads from above while the headlights of the lonely cars trailing each runner beamed over the endless expanse of pavement

appearing step by step in the glow. Throughout the race, runners slept in roadside cots, in piles of blankets in the seats of cars, or in actual lodging in towns or at roadside carparks. Those who hadn't paused in Petaluma or Santa Rosa all reached Healdsburg by morning. Some would have been on the road until hints of sunrise hit the horizon.

Day One was in the books, and people were hooked. Already, the race was down one runner, and others showed hints of problems with aching limbs or uncooperative coaches. The racers leading the field had just about conquered both Marin and most of Sonoma counties in their first stretch. They were about to leave the rolling agricultural valleys and encounter a landscape notably beyond the echoes of urban hubs. They were also about to run through a region with even more painful ties to the colonial past, and not an era centuries prior, but merely a few generations past. Given the immediate task at hand and labor of the opening day, one assumes that rather than contemplate the histories of the towns they ran through or would soon approach, each man hit the pillow and fell fast asleep.

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